

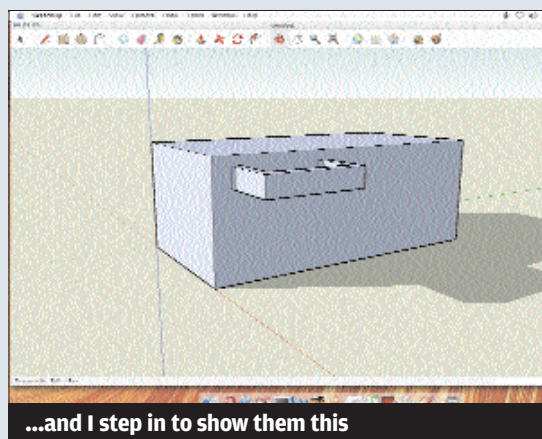
Getting New Furniture Made

Desks have this annoying way of collapsing the second they decide that the world has too many books for them to handle. There was also other furniture around the house that needed replacing, so it was time to summon the carpenters.

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The carpenters doing their usual act...



...and I step in to show them this

1

I describe the desk I want to the labourers. They listen intently and seem to comprehend, so this might go nice and smoothly like I'd hoped. Ah, naïveté...

There had to be a better way to get the rest of the furniture done, and the best way was to show them visually. I have the drawing skills of an epileptic rat, but I've been tinkering with Google SketchUp for a few days. I wonder...

2

The frame of the desk starts to look more like an oversized stool rather than the workstation I had asked them to make. This is unacceptable, so I get them to change it, explaining again exactly what I want at the bottom, and where I want the drawers.

I start with SketchUp, thinking that it'll take me just a few minutes to design a new cabinet; no such luck. I'm not limited by the software, but actually using those features to create something that will become real is a different ball-game.

3

The carpenters decide to use their own "creativity" to conjure up an abomination they call a footrest. This is all very disappointing, and I tell them so. Getting it re-done is going to take time, so I decide to live with it.

I struggle with SketchUp for a couple of hours, making sure that I use the exact measurements for the cabinet—I don't want to end up miscalculating anything.

4

And then they botch up the drawer. Turns out they miscalculated the length of the drawer, so now sitting at the desk makes opening it impossible, unless I'm willing to forgo some skin on my knee. Genius.

The cabinet's done, and I've verified the measurements and proportions a billion times. When I show it to them, the carpenters seem to realise that it's a Formidable Force they're dealing with, and get to work.

5

Well, at least the top's flat and the drawers open. I have to deal with the bizarre frame, but it doesn't interfere with my life so much.

This way is so much better. I've got my cabinet just the way I designed it!

Convenience Meter: **2** (Just short of murderous rampage)



Convenience Meter: **4** (Learning new skills takes time!)



AND
THE
WINNER
IS...

If you've got the time, inclination and the skill, design your furniture in Google SketchUp or similar software like 3D Home Creator, and then have your carpenters build it. If they have any snags on the way, you can

show them every detail in 3D, and they can't even come back at you with a "your instructions weren't clear" if things go wrong. Just make sure your proportions are right.